

occurred." The railway staff, themselves reeling from the effects of Partition, had risen to the occasion courageously. However, it was now time to rebuild and restore, so that the railways could once again truly connect a nation.

Restoring connections

Traffic patterns changed significantly after Partition. All traffic to northern India, which used to go via Karachi, now passed through Bombay, increasing the load on that system. Provisions were made on an urgent basis for more lines and yard facilities in that sector to handle the additional burden. An immediate issue was the rebuilding of connections to areas that were now isolated because of Partition. The state of Assam, which lost its rail link to the rest of the country with the creation of East Pakistan (modern-day Bangladesh), was of the biggest concern. It was now connected to the rest of India through a narrow 20-km-wide corridor. A massive relinking project, therefore, began in January 1948 and involved laying of 230 km of railway lines. It was completed in record time and opened to passenger traffic in January 1950 (see [Assam Relinked](#)).

There were also concerted efforts to relink Kashmir. Earlier, most trains connected Rawalpindi and Jammu via Lahore, after which one continued the journey by road. Now these lines had to go through Delhi. Work began in Punjab on the Mukerian–Pathankot line in November 1949 and was opened to the public in April 1952. This changed the face of Pathankot, previously a small station that catered only to the Kangra Valley Railway. It became the hub that received support traffic from Jammu. Efforts to link Kashmir via the rail continue, even today (see [Kashmir Connection](#)).